

I Am What Happens

A POETIC ALLEGORICAL EPIC IN SIX MOVEMENTS

I Am What Happens

*When You Try to Carve God from the Wood of
Your Own Hunger*

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I Am What Happens

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Invocation

For the one who mistook hunger for holiness,
and still kept walking.

For the one who carved an altar
from ache,
from absence,
from the old wood of wanting.

For the one who entered the forest
with no lamp but longing,
and found that every shadow
was asking to be seen.

Let this book be a threshold.

Let the reader come barefoot in spirit,
without weapon,
without certainty,
without the proud little crown
of being right.

Let the false gods fall gently
where they must fall.

Let the true fire survive them.

Let every wound become a doorway,
every question become a road,
every road become a return.

And when the final hunger is spent,

may what remains
be wide enough
to hold the soul.

A Note on the Form

This book is written as a continuous allegorical poem in six movements.

It follows a wanderer through forest, desert, city, valley, mountain, and return. These places are not meant only as locations. They are inner territories. The forest is the first confusion of the soul. The desert is the mind stripped of noise. The city is the vision of love and unity. The valley is the world's suffering. The mountain is the place of surrender. The return is the test of whether revelation can become service.

The poem draws from several streams of wisdom, including mystical Christianity, Platonism, Sufi devotion, Buddhist emptiness, mythic pilgrimage, and the older language of sacred trial. No single tradition is treated as a cage for truth. Each appears as a vessel, a symbol, a voice, a lamp held for a while in the dark.

The central question of the book is simple, though it takes the whole journey to approach it:

What happens when the soul tries to make God out of its own hunger?

At first, hunger leads the seeker forward. It gives him motion, courage, dissatisfaction, and the refusal to live by lesser answers. Yet hunger also deceives. It can carve idols from fear, ambition, loneliness, grief, and desire. It can mistake intensity for truth. It can bow before what it has secretly made.

The journey of the wanderer is therefore a journey of purification. He does not reject longing. He follows it until longing reveals its own limits. He learns that truth cannot be possessed as an object, that love cannot be hoarded as private bliss, and that illumination has no value unless it returns to the broken world with compassion in its hands.

The form of the book is intentionally elevated, ceremonial, and old in sound. Its language reaches toward the feeling of scripture, epic, parable, and prayer. The reader is invited to move through it slowly. This is not a book designed to be consumed in haste. It is meant to be entered.

Some passages may be read as philosophy. Some as spiritual allegory. Some as myth. Some as the record of one soul learning to stop worshiping its own need.

The title speaks from the far side of that transformation.

*I am what happens when you try to carve God from the wood of your
own hunger.*

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I

First Movement

LONGING

A forest. A hunger. A god not yet born.

LONGING

Nightfall approaches in the woods,
A wanderer stands with heart atremble bare,
An exile lost where shadow's secrets lie.
Forgotten path dim-lit by hope and prayer,
He drifts 'twixt cedars old as mortal sin;
Their boughs like elders in their silent stare.
The voice of dusk bid his quest begin,
As leaves in vespers sway with sigh and groan—
He wakes from world's illusions thick and thin.
In solitude, behold: he stands alone,
While dying sunbeams bleed in threads of gold,
His spirit famished, soul an empty throne.

Footfalls unsteady on a path untold,
He staggers deeper into yawning gloom,
His hunger carving out what hearts can't hold.
The forest hums a half-forgotten tune,
Chant of the ancients from a distant space,
Where Plato's Forms in silent vigil loom:
The True and Good beyond our earthly helm,
A world of patterns, primal and ideal,
Reflecting wisdom that mere flesh o'erwhelms.
This pilgrim yearns for truths no dream can steal,
But each step falters on the needful stone;
His mortal doubts around his ankles congeal.

The path like serpent coils 'neath mossy bone,
No straight road clear to promised shining gate;
Thus mortal mind by paradox is thrown.
An ashen fox darts past in frantic state,

A fleeting spectre 'cross the pilgrim's track;
Its feral eyes agleam with cunning fate.
That ember gaze which glows in fur of black
Seers through his essence to the hunger fraught,
As if to judge the burden on his back.
Our seeker shudders, conscience keenly caught,
By spectres of his sins that cease to rest,
Old idols carved from yearnings we have wrought.

In hush of eve the wood becomes confessor,
An altar carved of oak and thirst and flame,
His memories laid bare as by possessor.
Each trunk a pillar in this psychic frame,
Each root an anchor dragging down to truth—
He wades through recollection bound by shame.
There in the thicket, voice of quiet sooth
Calls from the cedar's heart in patient tone,
An elder spirit speaking to lost youth:
"O pilgrim, weary treading all alone,
What draws thee through this labyrinth of dread?
What thirst compels thy soul from hearth and home?"

The wanderer, startled, lifts his heavy head,
He scans the gloom for who addressed him thus
And spies an ancient hermit robed in red.
Bent by weight of years, beard silvery muss,
This figure smiles with eyes of ageless grace,
A gentle solace in the night's discuss.
He leans upon a staff of knotted lace,
Each twist of wood carved with an olden tongue,
Symbols of star and sun along its face.
His voice like leaves that withering have sung,
Yet strong enough to shake the cypress old:
"Seek ye in darkness what from light hath sprung?

Long have I waited in this midnight cold

For one whose hunger leads him to this gate,
 To test thy heart like iron in the mold.
 Heed now the path which secret tongues relate,
 For this dark forest hides the only door
 Into the truth beyond mere mortal fate.
 Though worn and lost, thy soul holds ancient lore;
 Within thee lies the spark of holy flame,
 To light the way where none have walked before.
 Fear not the shadow nor thy errant shame—
 Each step in darkness sets the spirit free.
 Thy hunger carves a god—here endeth game.”

The wanderer’s knees quiver suddenly,
 As though the earth itself had softly sighed;
 He bows before wisdom on bended knee.
 “Who art thou?” to the hermit he replied,
 Voice hoarse with thirst for counsel and for grace;
 “My spirit starves, by hollow dreams denied.
 In sooth, I come from life’s fruitless chase,
 Where every promise turned to dust and wind.
 No idol sates, no mortal wealth can place
 Contentment in my heart nor peace of mind.
 I yearn to grasp what ancient seers have known,
 A truth eternal none can break or bind.”

The hermit nods, as if these words were grown
 From seeds he planted eons past in time.
 “Thy thirst,” quoth he, “no less than mine hath shown—
 For mortal souls must rise through dirt and grime
 To sip the dew that hides on heaven’s bough.
 In hunger’s maw, desire becomes sublime.
 Mark well the path: what matters is the how,
 Not what illusions promise to provide.
 To carve a god from hunger shapes a vow,
 Yet knows not how to fill the void inside.

Step forth, my child, the journey must commence
Through rites of old where truth and self collide.”

So saying, he extends a hand immense,
A bony limb with strength of oaken age;
Our pilgrim clasps it, trusting in his sense.
With step in stride they breach the forest’s cage,
Where roots retreat and gloom concedes to night—
Each bough bent back to carve a narrow stage.
The wanderer follows, heart drumming contrite,
As though ascending some primordial stair
Where mind transcends this worldly fleshly plight.
The hermit leads, a flame beyond despair,
His staff aglow with runes of hidden light,
Illuming brambles in soft saffron glare.

In winding serpentines they climb through night,
Past skulls of fallen trees and beasts decayed;
In deathly ruin flickers insight’s sight.
Our seeker, in each trunk with rot arrayed,
Sees mirrored glimpses of himself undone,
As if his vice in wood and worm displayed.
Here lust, there pride, envy beneath the sun,
Carven in bark or crawling in the loam;
Ghosts of the soul transmuted one by one.
With each foul visage seen the more to roam,
He feels a shedding of some heavy weight,
A scale from ego peeled, another comb.

Thus purged by vision of each dire strait
His faltering heart had sailed by folly’s gale,
He feels new breath beyond his mortal state.
At last, they reach a clearing hushed and pale,
A glade where moonlight paints a silver dome,
An argent sea wherein ideas set sail.
The hermit stops beside a granite home

Of rugged stone with moss in ancient script,
 Its surface carved with creatures that do roam.
 This monolith in shimmering light is dripped,
 Pale sentinel of secrets to unfold;
 In each strange glyph a prophecy is crypt.

Upon its face the hermit's staff takes hold,
 His withered fingers trace a symbol raw—
 A triangle entwined with circle bold.
 At once, the stone begins to quake with awe,
 A moaning creak as doorway appears,
 Inviting them through mouth of ancient maw.
 With gracious nod, the sage allays his fears:
 "Behold the threshold to the deeper wood—
 There lies the temple of the hidden seers.
 What must be gleaned beyond is understood
 Not through the eyes alone but by the heart,
 And by the hunger that would carve a god."

Thus beckoned, pilgrim readies to depart
 This mortal glade for fields of mythic truth.
 Though fear yet coils, resolve withstands its smart.
 Into the darkness carved by ageless youth—
 The youthful hunger old as humankind—
 He steps behind his guide in twilight's ruth.
 Stone lips seal shut as soon as they enshrined
 Their passing forms, entombing them in night.
 No way but onward through the cavern blind.
 Though unaccustomed to this lack of sight,
 He feels the hermit's presence like a flame,
 Each footfall guided by that ghostly light.

Their path descends through corridors that claim
 The echoes of their steps in solemn halls,
 Where unseen choirs whisper secret Name.
 A spectral breeze through emptiness now calls,

Carrying chants of distant devotees,
In languages ere Babel's tower falls.
The wanderer's heart leaps—could one of these
Be those who from all climes sought wisdom high?
Now disembodied, swirling as the seas?
He whispers soft: "What voices here comply?
Are these illusions wrought by weary mind,
Or counsel's heralds drawn from space on high?"

The hermit's voice returns both calm and kind:
"Each echo here is memory of prayer,
A plea by pilgrims past now so entwined.
They sought in darkness paths beyond despair,
Carving their longing out of flesh and thought,
Invoking truth beyond what senses share.
Their words yet linger—lessons dearly bought—
To guide new seekers at the journey's start.
Heed well their ghostly choir where hope is wrought."
As if on cue, one voice from void apart
Rings clearly in that moment through the air:
"A fire is kindled by friction of heart with heart."

The wanderer clings to the hermit's care,
While stone beneath their feet slopes further down;
The darkness thickens, heavy to compare.
The guide's soft light in gloom a spectral crown,
Glinting on damp walls carved with mystic art—
In runes unknown the truth of yore is sown.
At length, a welcome glow begins to start
Ahead, an ember, like a lone star set
In midnight well beyond the world apart.
Their footsteps quicken, hope and caution met,
For at that flame an altar altar stands,
A vigil left in cavern's cryptic net.

They near and see, with eyes and heart and hands,

A lamp of ancient oil sputtering low,
 Upon an altar carved in these far lands.
 Each carving on its face speaks what we know
 And what we yearn yet still to comprehend—
 In swirling patterns, flames and trees do flow.
 In one corner a phoenix meets its end,
 In raging fire to ashes cold and grey,
 Yet from that ash climbs newborn to ascend.
 Another side: an oak stands in decay,
 Hollowed by age and struck by lightning white,
 But from charred stump shoots green to find its day.

And there, inscribed with gentlest of delight,
 A humble carpenter at work with wood
 Carves forms of beauty birthed from inner sight.
 Our wanderer beholds and understood
 The motif weaving through these varied scenes:
 Of transformation wrought from bad or good.
 Fire, wood, carving—visions each convenes
 To whisper something just beyond his grasp,
 Like half-forgotten tales from childhood dreams.
 His fingers trace the woodcarver's firm clasp
 Upon the chisel shaping holy face,
 Perhaps a god drawn out with each light rasp.

Then out from darkness steps in sudden grace
 A new arrival robed in raven black,
 A hood concealing visage from this place.
 Though silent footfalls gave no hint or track,
 Our wanderer senses presence now profound,
 A soul awakened from time's endless slack.
 The hermit bows to one on sacred ground,
 A greeting given not with word but heart,
 As if two kin by destiny are bound.
 The hooded one then draws a bit apart,

Unveiling ancient eyes both young and old,
Within whose depths universes impart.

The pilgrim trembles though not from the cold—
For recognition stirs in marrow deep,
As if those eyes his own essence behold.
A voice ensues from caverns half-asleep,
Gentle and fierce all in one measured note:
“Brave soul who dares through midnight gloom to creep,
What is it that you seek in worlds remote?”
The wanderer finds his voice with trembling sound:
“I seek the Truth beyond life’s antidote.
I seek to quench the thirst where none abound,
To know what meaning fires thee eternal wheel,
What hidden patterns in our fate are wound.”

The hooded figure nods with stern appeal,
And in those eyes a flame begins to dance,
A flicker born from fervor’s holy zeal.
“To hunger for the Truth is no mere chance,”
Intones the figure, raising slender hand,
“But mortal hearts can starve from ignorance.
To carve a god from hunger—understand—
Is to risk worship of a hollow form,
A phantom by desires falsely manned.
Thus path to wisdom first must bravely storm
Each vain illusion to the very core,
And break the idols by true vision shorn.”

Our wanderer hears and feels an ache he bore
Since earliest youth: the fear of being blind
To life’s grand meaning, lost forevermore.
He sees again those idols in the mind
That one by one in forest he had glimpsed—
Their promises false joys that ever bind.
In rising sorrow at a life misspent,

He bows his head, choked by a voiceless cry;
Two glistening tears from laden eyelids vent.
They drop upon the dusty stone to die,
Dark patches on the temple's ancient floor—
As though Earth drinks the offering from sky.

The hooded sage extends a hand once more
And lifts the pilgrim's chin with gentle grace,
"Your tears anoint the path we seek and soar.
Within your grief lies gift to here unlace,
For emptiness can hold the seed of all—
In void of sorrow sprouts joy's sacred face.
Now steel your spirit for what shall befall,
And trust the fire that purifies the soul;
We journey forth through zones beyond the wall."
At that, the hermit and this sage cajole
The wanderer toward a further gate,
A threshold leading to the second scroll.

The pilgrim stepping through with trembling feet,
His old life cast aside, stripped desolate.
In darkness borne by guiding lights he meets
A flicker of hope where wisdom's flame entreats.



II

Second Movement

FORMS

A chalice. A desert. The mind stripped bare.

FORMS

From womb of cavern into night's domain,
Our pilgrim surfaces in air so still—
Beneath a sky where stars in glory reign.
Beside him stands the hooded guide of will,
The hermit by the threshold fades from sight,
His task fulfilled at forest's secret hill.
Now only one companion in the night:
The raven-robed sage of ageless eyes,
Who points beyond to dunes of silver light.
A desert stretches under many billion stars,
Whose dunes roll like waves on that hallowed sea,
A barren expanse where silent truth lies.

The pilgrim shivers at immensity
Of emptiness that greets his searching gaze;
Yet feels a calm in desolate decree.
For in the desert's void, no voice betrays,
No clamor of the world to drown his thought—
Here soundless wisdom walks through Milky haze.
His hunger, once fierce-gnawing, now seems naught
Against the quiet of this endless span;
As though the emptiness is what he sought.
His companion steps forth on silver sand,
Barefoot yet leaving no footprints behind,
Gliding like thought across that subtle land.

With humble steps, the pilgrim in his mind
Follows, the weight of silence heavy-sweet;
Each dune a ripple from truth's breath designed.
They wander under moon's all-seeing seat,

The pilgrim's heart attuned to wisdom slight—
Perhaps from saintly souls once indiscreet,
Who trod this path in search of the Infinite.
At length upon the crest of one great dune,
They pause in awe beneath the astral light.
Before them lies a valley shaped like moon,
A crater vast and circled by dune walls,
As if a grail where distant secrets swoon.

Within this hollow, in the starlight's falls,
He spies a colonnade of pillars grand,
Ruins half-buried telling ancient calls.
Marble forms half sunk in shifting sand,
Their bases hidden, capitals askew,
Yet in their spacing a pattern is planned.
At center stands a plinth carved clean and true,
Polished black stone that drinks the silver glow;
Atop it glints a curious form to view.
He strains his eyes—what might the object show?
But distance veils it in uncertainty,
A beckoning mirage of truth to know.

The guide in raven robes turns suddenly,
His gaze upon the pilgrim intense:
“Proceed we must into this mystery.
These ruins mark where souls sought recompense
From life's illusions by a different art:
They shaped the Form of Forms from thought immense.
Be warned, dear pilgrim, keep pure in your heart;
For many who sought truth through Form's ideal
Found only shadows that tore them apart.”
Thus cautioned, down the dune with measured heel
They tread, descending to that ancient ring
Where columns stand as frozen turning wheel.

Entering the circle feels like crossing

A threshold into mind's reflective pool,
 Where each stray thought returns with doubled sting.
 The pilgrim senses presence mystical,
 Though none appears save dunes and ruined halls;
 He feels as if he stands in triune school—
 A trinity of sages without walls:
 For Greece's Plato seems to whisper near,
 While Eastern emptiness around him calls,
 And Sufi passion burns as desert sear,
 While Christian mystics hum through silent stone—
 All unseen in this space, yet all sincere.

Approaching now the plinth at circle's throne,
 The pilgrim sees what's glinting in the night—
 A chalice of crystal, like ice half-blown.
 It seems at first filled with the lunar light,
 But as he gazes, shifting tints appear:
 Now azure, now gold, now red ember bright.
 Within its depths swirl forms to eye unclear:
 He glimpses a rose that becomes a flame,
 A flame to a bird, a bird to a tear.
 Each shape gives way as soon as it became,
 Evanescent forms shimmering in glass,
 Like truth itself playing a lover's game.

His guide observes him in silence pass,
 Then speaks: "This chalice is the Mind's ideal,
 The Cup of Forms, reflecting all en masse.
 Philosophers conjured this as the seal
 Of that place where each fleeting shape below
 In purer essence doth itself reveal.
 The rose thou saw art Form of Rose aglow,
 The bird, the Form of flight and liberty,
 The flame, the Form of zeal that spirits know.
 Touch not the chalice yet; first, verily,

Discern what wisdom and what subtle snare
Lies in this shifting of eternity.”

The pilgrim peers again, heart laid more bare,
Allowing the visions to wash his soul.
He sees the rose again, beyond compare;
But now he feels its essence as a whole:
Not petals merely, but beauty and thorn,
The archetype of bloom, its timeless role.
The bird returns, a phoenix to be born,
Yet also eagle, sparrow, swan, and dove—
All flights of fancy to one mother sworn.
The flame that flickers now is more than love;
It is longing, anger, passion, and spark—
All heat of life from hearth to stars above.

Overwhelmed by insight sudden and stark,
He staggers back from the potent grail.
His mind a slate where primal forms mark
The patterns hidden behind life’s veil.
He gasps: “So Plato’s truth shines clear and bright—
Each earthly thing casts shadow of this tale.
If forms ideal abide in astral light,
Does mortal life but chase their phantom moves?
Are we but shadows in that cave’s midnight?”
The hooded guide replies, “In ignorance
Men oft mistake the shadow for the source.
Yet glimpsing Form can truth our steps enhance.”

Our pilgrim, enthralled yet troubled perforce,
Questions: “If beyond each form we see
Abides a Form eternal, sans remorse,
Then what of emptiness profound and free
That Buddhist sages claim as final state?
They teach that no form lasts eternally,
That all is void which we elaborate,

Dependent, fleeting, empty of selfhood—
 The cup a snare which egos fabricate.”
 At this the guide’s eyes spark beneath his hood,
 As though pleased the query has been raised;
 He circles the plinth, robes swirling as would
 Night’s own tempest around that chalice dazed.

In measured tone he speaks: “It is well phrased.
 Between Forms eternal and Emptiness
 Lies a seeming riddle leaving minds amazed.
 Some build their truths as structures luminous,
 Others like sand erase each shape in turn;
 Yet perhaps through paradox we progress.
 Those who hold that beyond is void and urn
 May find that void is space for all to be—
 A womb where forms arise and to dust yearn.
 Likewise, those fixed on Forms’ sanctity
 Might forget that forms are by love propelled—
 Mere empty outlines without charity.
 Thus Eastern emptiness and Greek mold meld
 When wisdom sees both thought and its release,
 A interplay between and beyond both held.”

The pilgrim ponders deep this intricate piece:
 That Form and emptiness in truth entwine.
 He sees within that union strange a peace—
 Like sculptor’s chisel carving to refine:
 Chipping away to find the form within,
 And empty space gives shape to new design.
 So emptiness yields form as form grows thin,
 And void and figure circle like the stars.
 His thoughts are fireflies swirling, still
 To meetings of minds resolving world’s wars
 Between being and nothing, shape and voids.
 In that understanding, sweet harmony endures.

As comprehension dawns, he is overjoyed,
But sudden a swirl of desert wind gusts
Across the ruins with fury deployed.
The dunes shift restless, sand rises like dusts
Of a thousand armies thundering near;
The pilgrim shields his eyes from spiteful thrusts.
Within that storm, whispering voices jeer,
And laughing phantoms form of swirling sand—
The air thick with shades of doubt and fear.
They encircle the plinth, a ghostly band,
Their laughter reverbing like shattered glass,
Each voice a sneer the pilgrim to disband:

“Thinkest thou truth is thine to grasp, alas?
Forms deceive, emptiness annihilates,
Poor mortal mind with burdens huge and vast!”
Another hiss: “What hunger desolates
Drives thee to carve a deity from need!
Thy quest is folly that pride celebrates!”
A third: “No hidden truth, just dust indeed,
Awaiting all who seek beyond their grave!”
The pilgrim staggers, stung by doubts that bleed,
His newfound insight rattled by this knave
Of inner demons dredged by fear’s monsoon—
He feels his courage waver, will enslave.

But then the guide’s voice cuts through: a rune
Chanted in a tongue older than the moon,
Each syllable a sunlit thought in tune.
The phantoms recoil, as shadows at noon
Shrink from the high meridian of day.
His words, though cryptic, make the storm opportune
To pass like nightmare smoke in dawn’s calm ray.
The desert hush returns beneath the night,
As last of swirling wraiths dissolves away.

The pilgrim, shaken, turns to the guide's sight,
 Whose raised hand slowly lowers with the peace;
 Within those eyes, a gentle, warming light.

"Courage," speaks the sage, "let not your heart cease.
 Those doubt-born phantoms guard each threshold true,
 To test if wisdom holds or will release.
 They are but reverbs of the self in you,
 The fears that knowledge renders life absurd,
 Or that all your strivings bear no value.
 Yet know this: meaning is not just conferred
 By answers grasped or heavens plans laid bare,
 But by the earnest seeking undeterred.
 In quest itself thy soul learns how to care,
 And by caring transformeth hunger's ache
 Into devotion's sacrificial prayer."

Our wanderer, still catching breath, did take
 These words like water on parched tongue of mind.
 He nodded slowly, new resolve awake.
 Then, guided by thought and the night's soft wind,
 They moved beyond the chalice on the stone,
 To see what further secrets they might find.
 Beyond the plinth, deeper in ruin's zone,
 They saw a narrow arch half-buried low,
 Leading beneath ground like a gaping cone.
 The pilgrim instinct felt an urge to go,
 As if a magnet pulled from deep within
 Towards that arch where unknown unknowns grow.

Without a word, though sharing one soul's kin,
 Guide and pilgrim advanced to the hidden door,
 And slipped beneath where darkness did begin.
 The starlight faded—blackness reigned once more,
 Save a faint luminescence from the guide,
 Like far-off torch reflecting on cave's floor.

They moved through a corridor cold and wide,
Walls carved smooth by ancient patient hand,
Curving as if to spiral heaven's side.
At length a glimmer shown—a light unmanned
Ahead, as tunnel opened to a space
Vast, silent, secret beneath the sand.

They entered a great hall, a tomb or place
Of gathering, though empty now and still;
Columns rose like giants in gloom's payload.
In the center, a brazier glowing shrill
With azure flame that cast unearthly light,
Shadows dancing like ghosts against their will.
The pilgrim's gaze was drawn to a sight:
Figures of marble surrounding the flame,
Statues in circle, count of eight in plight.
Each frozen sage mid-pose, their stony frame
Captured in act of discourse or of prayer,
As though counsel eternal they proclaim.

He stepped closer, and found each statue fair
Resembled a thinker or saint of lore:
Plato with finger raised as if in care
To heavens; Pythagoras on the floor
Drawing a triangle; Plotinus blind-eyed
In trance; an unknown yogi from far shore
Lotus-seated; a desert father tied
In contemplation; Bodhidharma stern;
A veiled woman, in Sufi calm she bides;
Lastly Aquinas with tomes to discern.
Eight figures from corners of earth and creed,
Gathered beyond time in stone as one to learn.

The hooded guide intones: "In this indeed
Is a counsel beyond mortal accord,
A conference of souls by wisdom freed.

Their discourses in life by time abhorred
 Meet here in likeness for thee to unite;
 Listen, if thou canst, with thine heart outpoured.”
 The pilgrim, awestruck, approached the blue light
 At center, and around the statues paced.
 In the flame’s flicker, eyes played trick of sight—
 He thought he saw their stony lips have traced
 Slight movements, as if each to speak in turn,
 Yet stillness reigned when fully he did face.

He closed his eyes the better to discern,
 And opened wide the ear within his chest,
 The heart’s listening where insight can burn.
 At once, a whisper came from east to west,
 A blast of voices now surrounding:
 To mortal hearing chaos at best,
 Yet in his soul, he perceived conceiving
 A harmony of thought beyond one tongue:
 The eight conversing truths past retrieving.
 His mind struggled to hold what thus was sung—
 For each sage gave from his own vantage point,
 Yet a unity through difference was strung.

Plato’s tone, lofty, bridged the Form sublime;
 Bodhidharma’s void thundered silently;
 The Sufi woman sang love’s paradigm;
 Aquinas reasoned divine subtly;
 The yogi breathed Om in transcendence;
 Plotinus praised the One ineffably;
 Desert father whispered in penitence;
 Pythagoras intoned number and sphere.
 Each distinct strain by turns took precedence,
 But none drowned out the others from his ear.
 Instead like instruments of one ensemble,
 Their counterpoint made heavens music clear.

Within this wordless yet wordful rumble,
A meaning emerged that encompassed all:
Truth wears many garments, yet one humble
Light animates the patterns that enthrall.
Forms give outlines to truth, emptiness space;
Love ignites purpose as to flame a pall.
Reason maps structure, faith yields hope and grace;
The One beyond gives rise to the many,
And many seek the One in every place.
The pilgrim's mind opened as if any
Boundary between these thoughts dissolved whole—
He felt truth's wine pour from a common fount many.

Tears of wonder now from his eyelids stole,
As he grasped that wisdom is vast, a sea
No doctrine can contain in its bowl.
All these streams—Platonic, Christian, Sufi,
Buddhist and beyond—converged in the deep,
Where truth's pearl glows in dark serenity.
He realized then that though hunger keep
His soul restless, it also spurred him on
To find that unity where differences sleep.
The hooded guide watched as epiphany dawn
Across the pilgrim's countenance so slight—
A smile, a glow like rose at break of dawn.

At last the pilgrim spoke, voice soft with light:
"I see a glimpse of what I cannot hold,
Yet 'tis enough to guide my further plight.
Each tradition a story that is told
In different tongue, yet meaning overlapped,
Like sculptors chiseling the selfsame mold.
No one tale holds truth wholly in its clasp,
Yet truth holds all the tales in its embrace.
And my hunger to know has been perhaps

The carving tool that shapes my inner space
 To hold more wisdom than I could at first,
 Making me empty so truth may have place.”

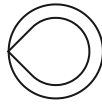
He turned toward the hooded guide, eyes burst
 With grateful fire. But he found no one.
 Alone he stood where diverse wisdoms conversed.
 The space now silent; each statue undone—
 For when he opened his worldly eyes to see,
 Nothing but vacant dust where flame had run.
 Had all that been a vision given free?
 The hall now empty as a desert tomb,
 No statue, no flame, just memory’s key.
 Yet knowledge lived beyond that vanished room
 In his heart, and guided by its spark,
 He knew to journey on beyond this womb.

He found in one corner by darkness stark
 Another passage, upward it did wind,
 From tomb to surface, to the desert dark.
 Ascending through the corridor he pined
 For the guide who vanished as dew at dawn,
 Yet carried onward what he’d left behind:
 The teachings gleaned from counsel vagabond.
 At last he emerged on the desert plain
 Under starry sky feeling less forlorn.
 The dunes glistened silver, whispering refrain
 Of the wisdom gained in halls below,
 And his soul felt cleansed as by gentle rain.

The pilgrim pressed on, with no guide to show,
 Trusting the silent voice within his heart
 To steer his steps to wherever he must go.
 Each dune he scaled, slid down, and climbed anew,
 Gyrating breath of earth beneath his tread,
 While overhead infinite worlds in view.

At times he paused, considered all he'd read
In those silent voices of mystic trance,
Then onward pressed by thirst still spirit-led.
For truth once glimpsed grants hunger no repose;
It spurs the seeker to deeper expanse,
To find at last the spring where wisdom flows.

The pilgrim crossing desert void and grand,
A crucible where Form and Void enhance.
His journey flows as shifting silver sand,
And onward shall you wend.



III

Third Movement

BELOVED

A city. A song. Love wearing golden light.

BELOVED

Through night he trudged until first blush did bloom,
With dawn's faint rose caressing eastern sky.
The desert's edge gave way as sand made room
For firmer earth where life could multiply.
Scrub brush and acacia in clusters spread,
A hint that verdant lands at last lie nigh.
The pilgrim's weary feet now lighter tread,
Buoyed by hope of water and reprieve,
And inner thirst to see what lay ahead.
Soon purpling hills did dawn's hues receive,
And beyond them, hints of spires glinting bright—
A city ancient, he could scarce believe.

He crested one last dune in golden light,
And lo, before him stretched a valley green,
Cradling a river shimmering in might.
Beside its banks, a marble city seen
Whose walls and towers reached for azure dome,
Crowned by a massive temple pure and sheen.
The pilgrim's heart quickened at that sight home;
For in the grandeur of that mystic place,
He sensed he neared the source for which he'd roam.
As he descended, sun's warmth did embrace
His aching limbs and heart's uncertain beat,
Filling him with new vigor, joy, and grace.

A winding path led down to where the sweet
Waters of the broad river gently flowed.
A stone bridge arched invitingly to meet
The city gates where giant statues showed:

Carved cherubim and beasts of mythic lore,
Wardens of secrets behind walls bestowed.
But by the river's bank he paused before
Crossing, drawn by laughter and singing clear,
Carried by morning's breeze from further shore.
Turning aside, he sought the sound so dear,
And soon came upon children at their play,
Dancing in shallows where the water's near.

They splashed and giggled in the new-born day,
Chasing reeds fashioned as makeshift ships,
Their faces bright as dawn in merry fray.
Their garb was humble linen, girded hips,
And skin of varying hues as earth can show—
Some bronzed by sun, some fair as lunar eclipse.
One boy caught sight of the pilgrim and so
Stood still, causing the others pause to gaze.
The wanderer smiled and bent his head low.
“Good morrow, children. What tune do you raise
That gladdens the heart of a traveler lone?
Whence comes your joy in these early sun rays?”

A girl stepped forth with a flower crown sewn
Of river lilies in her tangled hair,
She offered one to him in gentle tone.
“Mister, we greet you! We have no despair
In our fair city, which we call The Beloved—
All who enter find hope and solace there.
We sing songs that our elders long have loved,
Of heroes, of angels, of saints and kings,
But most of all, of Love that all behoved.”
Another child piped up, excitement brings:
“Yes! You must come. Today is a feast day!
In the great Temple the high choir sings.”

The pilgrim felt a tug as if to say

This chance meeting was more than happenstance.
 He graciously took the lily bouquet,
 Thanking each child with a kind, warm glance.
 Then taking leave, he crossed the arcing bridge,
 Towards city gates in reverent advance.
 Massive doors stood open; above, on ridge
 Of the arch, engraved words in script antique:
 "Welcome ye thirsty, hereto knowledge's ridge."
 Guards were none but stone statues mystique,
 Their visages calm with wisdom and peace,
 No swords, for none were needed to keep pique.

He stepped inside; marvels did not cease.
 Wide boulevards with colonnades aligned,
 Lining streets in harmony as if fleece
 Of marble softened outlines well-designed.
 Gardens spilled fragrance into open squares
 Where fountains leaped in arcs silver-refined.
 Folk ambled gently, no rushing affairs;
 Their faces content, eyes bright with purpose clear,
 As if each soul a hidden radiance bears.
 Men, women, and children moved without fear;
 Some in lively chat, others deep in thought,
 All neighbors in goodness sincere.

At the city's heart, dominating wrought,
 A temple soared of alabaster white,
 With golden dome with morning's fire caught.
 Courtyards wide encircled it, trees bedight
 With blossoms of myriad hue and shape,
 Perfuming breeze with sacred delight.
 Our pilgrim realized as jaw agape
 That his steps had led him to a domain
 Seemingly earthly, yet as vision drape
 It felt heaven-kissed, free of sorrow's stain.

He wondered if in truth it was utopia,
Or a test disguised in pleasure's fane.

Seeking guidance and to quell myopia,
He approached an elder under an oak,
A man reading scrolls of wide cyclopaedia.
"Sir," he ventured in gentle, cautious spoke,
"Pray tell me of this city wondrous fair;
I am a stranger, guided by some stroke
Of providence, drawn by children to care
That this day is sacred—some feast or rite.
What ethos rules this place beyond compare?"
The old man lifted eyes with friendly light,
"Welcome, friend. You've arrived on hallowed day:
We celebrate The Festival of Sight.

Our city, Beloved, by name we say,
Holds dear all seekers who yearn for the True;
We honor all paths that lead through dismay
Into hopeful virtue and knowledge too.
Our founders were mystics, sages, and seers
From lands far-flung, each a different hue
Of faith and wisdom. They shed mutual tears
Over humanity's endless discord,
And dreamed a city where love endures.
Together they labored, one mind, accord,
To build this haven for hearts and minds;
The Temple you see is their great reward.

In that Temple we keep the flame that binds,
Kindled from altars of East and of West,
A fire eternal where truth one finds.
Today, as dawn gilds our city's crest,
We gather, all citizens hand in hand,
To seek inner sight and to greet each guest.
You come fortuitous, as if by plan,

For all are welcome at the Feast of Sight;
 Join us and see what our rites command.”
 The pilgrim listened, heart warmed by insight,
 For this city seemed embodiment plain
 Of what he glimpsed in last moment’s midnight.

He thanked the elder, then strolled to the fane,
 Temple steps of marble smooth and pristine,
 Mingling now with a crowd in joyful train.
 People greeted him kindly, faces serene,
 As though a long-lost friend had come back home;
 He felt acceptance like a gentle rain.
 Ascending stairs with many a smooth dome
 He passed through columns in open foyer,
 Into a hall wide as starry sky’s roam.
 High above soared a dome that would inspire
 The greatest cathedrals to humility:
 At its center an oculus of fire.

Sunlight poured through that eye, nobility
 Cascading golden beams across the space,
 Illuminating murals of nobility:
 Scenes of compassion, courage and grace,
 Drawn from scriptures and epics of each way—
 Krishna and Arjuna in war’s embrace,
 Abraham and Isaac, moment they pray,
 Buddha under Bodhi tree radiant,
 Christ on the Cross forgiving in decay,
 Rumi with reed pen swirling aspirant,
 Lao Tzu wandering with water’s ease,
 Joan in flames unyielding and defiant.

Every pillar told stories such as these,
 In art entwining world’s faith and lore,
 No one triumphant over others to seize
 Pride of place—all were honored at core.

The pilgrim beheld these wonders in awe,
Feeling each story a truth to explore,
And in each figure's eyes a love he saw,
One source behind their myriad eyes aflame:
As if one Beloved did through all draw.
Then the assembly gathered, and words came,
A hush as robed choirs took their rightful place,
Preparing the hymn for festival's aim.

A hush of expectancy filled the space;
The pilgrim slid into a pew of oak,
Beside a family with kindness on face.
Then a single bell in the silence broke—
Not loud, but with resonance pure and deep,
Like heart's own note in solitude awoke.
Three times it tolled as souls willing to weep
At truth's beauty felt tears rise unbidden;
With each toll, silence seemed deeper to seep.
Then, out of hush, a soprano, hidden,
Rose in chant, in Latin or tongue unknown,
A plaintive call as if to Eden.

As her voice soared, more voices were grown
Each after each in different dialect,
One in Sanskrit, one Arabic intone,
Greek, Hebrew, Chinese—each did interject
Their praise of the Highest in native tongue,
Yet strangely harmonized as if perfect.
A melody thus deftly strung
Enraptured all, including pilgrim's heart;
He felt as if heaven's gate had unclung.
The hymn built in power, each voice a part
Of an ever-rising wave of the soul,
Crashing in unison at chorus's start.

Then all tongues together, without control,

Sang one phrase clear that all could understand—

“Open our eyes to the Beloved Whole!”

The dome above seemed to shake as if fanned

By wings of seraphs echoing that prayer;

Light from the oculus grew and did expand.

The pilgrim felt love beyond all compare

Pour from that sound and light into his core,

Washing away every lingering care.

He closed his eyes, tears flowing more and more,

And in his mind’s eye saw a vision bright:

A figure, faceless, opening a door.

The figure beckoned him in shining white,

And beyond the door lay a boundless field

Where golden lilies swayed in heavenly light.

He stepped through in spirit, senses unsealed,

And walked amidst that endless living gold,

Feeling all secrets of existence yield.

In each lily, a story would unfold,

Of a soul’s journey or an atom’s dance;

In each petal, infinity he could behold.

He heard silent music and watched entranced

As the sky rippled color never seen,

And beings moved beyond comprehension’s glance.

Then came a presence gentle and serene—

The sense of an embrace without form,

As though the field itself in love did lean.

Words unspoken draped him cozy and warm:

“You are beloved, child of dust and star,

No longer roam in fear of worldly storm.

Within you burns our flame, near or far;

Your hunger is our signal guiding true,

Through strife and night to where the good things are.

Know that you seek us as we seek you,

In hidden ways through conscience, through longing,
Each moment a string in love's element new."

The pilgrim soul replied, heartbeats thronging,
"Tell me, who are you?" though he felt he knew—
The answer came like a bell song ringing:
"I am the Beloved and the Seeker too,
Alpha and Omega of each quest,
The emptiness that yields fullness anew.
I have been with you when you thought suppressed,
In forest dark and desert of despair,
I am your hunger and your needed rest.
All forms of the Good, True, Beautiful fair
Are facets of me calling from above,
Yet also the void wherein these appear."

At that, the pilgrim felt overwhelming love,
A union as if every vein did pulse
With life eternal, below and above.
He wanted to linger in that impulse,
Yet as the choir's final chord did peal,
The vision faded back to temple's halls.
He opened his eyes, needing time to feel
The fullness of what had been shown within.
Congregants sat in silence after zeal;
Not a rustle disturbed peace genuine.
At length the officiant, an elder wise,
Gave gentle benediction to all kin:

"May the Beloved open all our eyes
To see beyond forms to the heart of grace,
And through emptiness let true sight arise."
The assembly stirred, joy on every face,
And slowly filed to courtyards bright outside
To break the fast with bread and fruit apace.
The pilgrim moved as if mystified,

In daze of bliss from vision's high bequest,
 Unsure if he dreamed or crossed some divide.
 As he wandered out, hand on heart impressed,
 He nearly stumbled into one waiting:
 The Sufi woman statue brought to life, no less.

It was she—no longer stone, but breathing,
 The same veiled form he'd glimpsed in desert hall;
 Now flesh and blood, with kind eyes all-seeing.
 He caught his breath at the marvel and awe.
 She smiled beneath her veil and bowed her head.
 "I greet you again, seeker who saw
 Our counsel in the sand. You have been led
 Truly, as your vision in song revealed.
 Yet your journey goes on, not finished or dead.
 The hunger that stirred you, that truth unsealed,
 Must now be tempered into living flame—
 A fire of love with integrity sealed.

Not for your sake alone is wisdom's name
 Engraved upon your heart by mystic light,
 But to serve others caught in fear or shame.
 Beloved City gave you a taste bright
 Of unity and peace which souls can reach;
 But beyond our gates roars the endless night
 Of world's sorrow, conflict, folly, and breach.
 Many hunger still for what you have seen,
 Blind in the darkness with no guiding speech.
 To rest here in bliss, while outside they keen,
 Would squander grace into stagnation's mire,
 For wisdom unused withers, dull of sheen."

The pilgrim listened, a chord struck in lyre
 Of his conscience; he felt truth in her word.
 Part of him longed to rest, a selfish desire,
 To dwell forever where his heart was stirred

By love and knowledge weaving sweet accord.
But the image of others lost, unheard,
Wandering as he had in darkness, roared
Through memory—a call he could not blight.
He remembered phantoms and forest cord,
His own despair before he had the sight.
How could he feast while others starve in gloom?
To share this grace felt a sacred right.

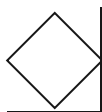
She saw resolve like dawn on him illume,
And gently placed a hand upon his arm.
“North of here beyond the valley’s bloom,
Past mountain crags where winds blow fierce alarm,
Lie lands wracked by war, ignorance, and grief.
We send envoys, healing hands to calm
And guide those willing toward soul’s relief.
Go, join their number, for your journey calls
Not to an end in comfort’s motif
But to service where divine duty falls.
Before you depart, take this gift from me—”
From her robe she withdrew two shawls.

One shawl was earth-brown, plain for all to see,
The other sky-blue embroidered with gold.
She offered the first: “Wear this humbly.
In rough lands you’ll tread, blend as common mold,
A simple monk or healer to their eyes.
It’s through humility your strength takes hold.”
The second shawl she held with care precise:
“This one keep hidden till the moment true,
It bears enchantments of the mystic wise.
When despair encircles and confounds you,
Unfurl it to remember the Highest,
The Beloved’s light will then surround you.”

He accepted both with bowed head in trust,

Grateful beyond words for her wise accord.
“Thank you,” he breathed. “I will do as you must
If it pleases the Beloved, my lord.”
She chuckled softly, a melody bright,
“Service pleases the One without reward.
Go well, dear seeker, walk within the Light.”
With that, she turned and merged into the crowd,
A single dove took flight in sky’s delight.
The pilgrim stood, heart steady now and vowed
To carry forth the unity he’d learned
Into the broken world beyond this cloud.

He made his way out gates where first he yearned,
Crossing the bridge from paradise to pale
Wild lands beyond, where cruelty burned.
As he left, the children he’d met set sail
On their reed boats waved from the river’s brim,
And he smiled and waved back without fail.
Thus from beloved city’s vision dim
He journeyed onward, purpose newly cast:
To quench thirst of others filled to the brim.
This moment closes as he travels fast
To distant valleys where suffering calls,
With love aflame to heal wounds of the past.



IV

Fourth Movement

TRIALS

A valley. A wound. Service under ash.

TRIALS

Beyond the sheltered valley of delight,
Our pilgrim ventured into lands unknown.
Soon verdant fields gave way to blighted sight:
Charred remnants of forests blackened and prone,
Villages in ruin, roofs caved and charred,
And silence where once life's vibrance was sown.
This was a land where hope had been marred,
Where war or plague left marks of misery;
Stench of despair in air heavy and tarred.
He wrapped the plain brown shawl about gently,
Hiding his glowing robe of inner peace,
To walk among the lost as no one but he.

In a hamlet scorched, his steps did decrease;
He saw gaunt faces peering from huts torn,
Eyes hollow, suspicious, begging surcease.
From house to house, burnt shafts of wheat forlorn
Stood charcoaled in fields where famine held reign.
Children cried feebly, weak from empty morn.
The pilgrim's heart clenched seeing so much pain:
Here wisdom's lofty light seemed far away,
Hunger of flesh overcame hunger of brain.
He approached a rubble well where they say
A few villagers gathered to draw
Muddy water for their thirst day by day.

As he neared, their voices hushed into awe,
Not reverent but wary of the strange,
For travelers were rare since ruin did gnaw.
He offered greeting, careful not to change

Their comfort by any holy pretense.
He asked what happened, what made fortune estrange.
An elder with face of grief deep and dense
Answered slow, voice raspy from smoke and fear:
“Plague came first, then soldiers crossing from hence
To elsewhere; they burned all and left us mere
To fend among ashes of kith and kin.
We survive barely; death ever is near.”

One woman with babe too weak to grin
Looked up with desperate hope and hollow eyes:
“Do you bring aid or care? Our lives grow thin.”
The pilgrim nodded, sorrowed by their cries.
Not a doctor nor wealthy lord was he,
Yet something from his journey might suffice.
“I carry little, yet what I have, see—”
He reached into satchel and produced bread,
Unbroken loaves three from Beloved City.
He gave them out to hands trembling in dread,
And to the well, went to draw water fresh;
He had seen near valley a stream’s riverbed.

Boiling the water to cleanse death’s thresh,
He helped them drink, and those too weak he fed.
From house to house he moved, driven enmesh
By compassion, caring not how he bled
From cuts or exhaustion or hunger pangs.
Day turned to dusk as he ministered ahead.
Though no miracle, except comfort and simple charity,
A spark lit in eyes where hopelessness hangs.
At night they offered him sanctuary
In a hut half-standing, to share their rest.
He sat by a small fire; they huddled free.

Under broken roof they felt strangely blessed;
The pilgrim told them of no city grand

But offered prayers and songs at their behest.
 A lullaby from his childhood land
 He sang soft, as mothers nod in relief,
 And children for a moment dreams command
 Chasing butterflies instead of grief.
 In that gentle timbre tears quietly fell
 From war-scarred souls, cathartic healing brief.
 They asked who he was, why he chose to dwell
 With destitute strangers in a wasteland.
 He answered humbly, truth in what he'd tell:

"I was once lost in darkness, 'til a hand
 Led me through forests and deserts of doubt.
 Now I follow an inner light's command
 To go wherever despair lies about
 And simply share what gifts I've received:
 Kindness, knowledge, hope's seed to sprout.
 My name matters not, nor could be believed,
 I'm but a seeker learning to give back
 For all the mercy that my soul relieved."
 They marveled, yet further questions did stack,
 So he spent the evening recounting mild
 Tales of wisdom gleaned on his mystic track.

He spoke of hunger that can't be exiled
 By food or drink, a thirst of soul and mind;
 How emptiness and form in union smiled.
 Though much was abstruse, they found him kind
 And slept more peaceful with him in their midst,
 As if his presence left balm left behind.
 At dawn he rose to leave, yet they insist
 He stays longer, fearing what lies beyond.
 But he, on path, by duty's call was kissed.
 He promised to send help from where is fond—
 Maybe the City of the Beloved's aid,

Though distant, their goodwill might respond.

He left amidst thanks and blessings prayed,
Continuing north where mountains did loom.
Each step a question: Could all this be stayed—
These cycles of suffering, violence, doom?
He had seen the heights of human spirit,
Now the depths of our woe in contrast fume.
How to bridge the gulf? Could love clear it?
He remembered the Sufi's admonition:
Not for self alone is the holy writ.
Trial and sorrow refine our mission,
As fire to gold or chisel to stone,
So compassion must grow from vision.

While crossing rocky passes ragged grown,
He encountered bandits famished and cruel—
Fleeing those wars but predating alone.
They beset him, five men armed as a rule,
Demanding coin or bread or life thereby.
The pilgrim had naught but his inner jewel.
He calmly met their gaze and did not lie:
“I have no gold, only a loaf to eat,
Which I will gladly share though small supply.”
The ruffians, perplexed by this man they meet
Who showed no fear and offered freely bread,
Lowered weapons though desperate minds compete.

One snatched the loaf and split it to shred,
Devouring half, giving half to others.
They then argued if to strike him dead—
For what use a man with empty druthers?
One with scarred face spat, “He'll slow us, no gain.”
Another, younger, “He could guide like brothers.
He seems a holy beggar, maybe slain
If left alone in these mountains by foes.”

The leader sneered, "Peace, boys, keep your brain.
 We took his food; leave him to vultures and crows."
 They turned to go; the pilgrim raised his voice,
 Something compelled him, compassion that grows:

"My friends," he called, making an earnest choice,
 "You have my bread, but I see deeper need.
 Your eyes speak troubles—can we not rejoice
 In finding common solace though we bleed?
 I too have walked through sorrows and through strife;
 If you will listen, I offer a creed."
 They paused, amused perhaps by captive life,
 To humor him or bored upon the road.
 He seized the moment to defuse their knife.
 He spoke of a city where love bestowed
 And exiles and strangers were welcome all,
 Where one's past misdeeds no longer corrode.

He saw in their stances some anger stall,
 The younger looked down shame-faced at his blade.
 "Many a man," said pilgrim, "has heard the call
 To start again despite mistakes he's made.
 If hunger drives you, there are kinder ways
 Than taking from others in fear's charade.
 You have strength and wit—perhaps this displays
 You could protect rather than prey upon.
 Come with me forward; see if hope conveys."
 They muttered among them: trust not yet drawn,
 But seeds of doubt in their path had been sown.
 Finally, scar-face grunts, "our time is gone."

They left him alive, perplexed and windblown,
 Heading elsewhere as pilgrim watched them pass.
 He sighed, wishing grace had been more clearly shown.
 Not every soul is ready to amass
 The insight to turn from violence to grace.

Some require time or further horrors amass.
He prayed softly for each bandit's soul space,
That one day their hunger too find the light,
Then resumed journey at an even pace.
Over crags and high valleys tinted slight
With autumn's palette he wandered long,
Helping as he could each suffering wight.

He tended the lost, guided with a song
A crazed soldier away from a cliff's edge,
Shared his cloak with a widow night wind strong,
Spoke calming word to a youth with raw dredge
Of nightmares from battles he'd fled afar.
To each person he gave from wisdom's hedge
One leaf of truth to heal their inner scar.
Some scoffed or ignored, but many a face
Lit with faint hope as though seeing a star.
And even when progress seemed slow in pace,
Each act of kindness lit two lives at least—
The giver and receiver share one grace.

Yet the valley's trials had not yet ceased.
As he entered a gorge of red-stone walls,
A swirl of dust forewarned nature not pleased.
The earth groaned low and sudden darkness falls—
A rockslide! Boulders from on high cascade.
The pilgrim barely jumps as death befalls.
Stones crash behind him in a roaring raid,
Trapping him in the gorge with no retreat.
Forward the only path now he must wade.
With staff in hand, he moved wounded feet,
Checking for fractures, but seemed all intact,
Saved for bruises and cuts minor concrete.

He thanked providence for life's continued tact
And pressed on through narrow canyon's heart,

Cliffs looming close as if heavens they propped.
 The path grew dim; high walls a roof impart
 That only noon's sun could briefly pervade.
 In gloom he walked like wandering in art
 Of Caravaggio—darkness with light bade
 Only at edges where a hope glimmers.
 He thought of Plato's cave and those who stayed,
 Chained in shadow, mistaking flicker for whispers.
 How different this canyon where he chose to roam
 Armed with inner light, though night shivers.

At a bend, he found an old man alone,
 Collapsed by the wall, breathing faint and hard.
 Rushing forth, the pilgrim in gentle tone
 Checked for wounds and gave water from his gourd.
 The old man's eyes opened milky and wide,
 His garb tattered, he clearly traveled far.
 "Water..." he croaked; the pilgrim did provide,
 Lifting the flask to cracked lips of white.
 After slow sips, he regained some pride.
 "Thank you," he said, voice raspy as midnight.
 He tried to stand, faltered—our friend held fast.
 "Rest, father," said the pilgrim, "no need for might."

Tears from the elder's eyes fell thick and fast.
 "Not father... just a fool chasing folly.
 I left my home for treasure unsurpassed.
 I have nothing—ambition ate me wholly.
 If not for you, I'd perish in this hell."
 The pilgrim saw guilt o'er his face like ivy.
 "All paths teach," he said, "and mistakes do tell
 What truly matters to heart and spirit.
 Your life yet is spared; thus use it well."
 The old man wept, "I chased a myth, a writ
 In ancient text of a relic divine—

The Sword of Solomon, if one could find it,

Would grant dominion o'er life's design,

Wisdom and power beyond mortal ken.

I lost companions, spent fortunes supine,

Seeking that blade through mountain and glen.

And now, empty-handed, near death I lie,

My quest in ruin, memory a fen."

He coughed, and the pilgrim wiped tears dry.

"Gently, friend," he soothed, "your value's not lost

Though false treasure lured your years to die.

The wisdom you sought cannot be exhaust

From an object or single secret lore;

It lives in each trial and tempest crossed."

The man sighed, "My life wasted and deplore;

I left my family, my children grown old

Without their father—what was it all for?"

"Perhaps," said pilgrim, "the story untold

Is not over yet. You breathe, thus you live.

Return home, mend bonds, let love you enfold."

The old man nodded weakly, hope a sieve

But slowly refilling drop by drop.

"I shall try if strength and fortune give."

The pilgrim gave bread and stayed until stop

Of day, when old man felt enough renewed.

Together they left canyon at sun's drop.

Parting at crossroads, the elder subdued

Thanked the pilgrim as if an angel came.

Each resumed journey by destiny's feud.

Our pilgrim onward, the valley to tame,

Climbed out of gorge to plateaus ahead,

Where rumor spoke of lands savage with flame.

He steeled himself, remembering the red

Shawl with golden threads, in case of dire need—

Though not yet invoked, it stayed in his stead.
 The valley of trials still held more deed:
 He entered a plain where two armies massed,
 Banners of hatred driving each stampede.

Caught in between, he saw spears in contrast,
 A battle impending for reasons lost—
 Old grudges, new slights, the die had been cast.
 Villagers fled before blades were crossed;
 He ran to a hillock to better view,
 Heart pounding for blood about to be tossed.
 Though no warrior, he felt he must do
 What he could to prevent the coming fray.
 But what can one man against war pursue?
 As horns blared and both sides formed array,
 He recalled the shawl of sky with gold sown—
 The mystic gift for despair's darkest day.

Surely, preventing slaughter's thunder blown
 Was cause to invoke whatever power
 Lay in that garment by sages known.
 He took cover behind an ancient tower,
 Now ruined, on that hill between the hosts,
 And drew from pack the blue shawl at hour.
 Unfurling its length, embroidered with ghosts
 Of symbols arcane, stars and swirling flames,
 He wrapped it 'round his shoulders as war looms close.
 He stepped forth, heart praying in all great names
 Of the Beloved across creeds and lands:
 "One Light, guide me that hate I may tame."

Down the slope he walked with upraised hands,
 Between armies now charging with fell cry.
 A surreal sight—one man against war's bands.
 At first none noticed in battle-high,
 Then those at front saw a figure calm,

Thinking perhaps some sorcerer is nigh.
Arrows loosed from nervous archers' palm,
But strangely, each shaft curved away mid-flight,
As if a wind of heaven made them qualm.
The blue shawl glimmered now with inner light,
Each golden thread like filaments aflame,
Forming a halo brightening the dire sight.

Both sides faltered as wonder overcame—
Superstitious dread that gods took part.
The pilgrim seized the moment in proclaim:
“Brothers! Sisters! Why tear each other apart?
What demon or false fear drives you to kill?
What sacred life can your sword re-start?”
His voice rang out, preternaturally shrill,
Amplified by shawl's enchantment bestowed,
Echoing off hills, the battle to still.
The combatants, bewildered, dropped their goad
A few paces from clash, unsure, amazed
At this lone figure in shimmering load.

He continued, the magic in him blazed:
“Look across: the face of your enemy—
Is it not human, with eyes fear-raised,
With heart that can bleed and dreams that can be?
What do you defend that by slaughter gained
Will not curse your children's legacy?
Every life lost, each soul by hate stained,
Summons a grief that never will depart—
Even victors are by their violence pained.
Lay down your arms, listen with your heart:
The Beloved has made all in one mold,
What you do to another, to yourself you impart.”

Some dropped their weapons, others yet hold,
But none advanced as conscience took root.

Then murmurs as leaders sought to be bold—
 Two generals rode out to quell dispute.
 They met in center near where pilgrim stood,
 Scowling at each other in pride's salute.
 "Who are you," one barked, "who in our war intrude?
 Sorcerer, saint or demon? By what right
 Do you meddle in our people's feud?"
 The other growled, "We fight for sacred right,
 Our cause is just, this fool best stand aside,
 Or by our blades he too shall feel their bite."

The pilgrim drew a breath, pushed fear aside,
 His shawl's glow flickered as doubt grazed his mind—
 But he anchored in faith to stem that tide.
 "In truth, I am no more than human kind,
 A wanderer who has seen much sorrow.
 No sorcerer nor warrior you'll find.
 My right to speak is love, to peace avow.
 If your cause be just, test it against this:
 Can it stand in dialogue come tomorrow?
 If enmity is ancient, dare to dis
 Instead of bodies, break hatred itself,
 Find common stories where now trust amiss."

The soldiers looked restless, the generals elf-
 Like cunning tried to exploit the crowd's lull.
 One sneered: "His tongue bewitches like a sylph.
 Hear me, warriors! This trick is a gull
 To rob you of glory and righteous pride."
 Some men roared approval, senses dull.
 The pilgrim realized words might slide
 Off hardened hearts drunk on promised reward.
 Perhaps demonstration must coincide.
 He remembered lessons in city stored—
 How they lit one flame from many a creed,

And from emptiness synergy is poured.

He asked each general, "Do you believe in God or creed?

One said 'I honor Mars, god of war's strife.'

The other: 'I worship justice indeed.'

Then to both, pilgrim bowed, no hint of knife:

"Then swear by whatever it is you adore

That your cause is worth this spilling of life.

If truly divine sanction you implore,

Then let that divine give judgement here.

Consent to a truce for just one day more.

Meet in parley, let each your case make clear,

Without arrow or sword, let the truth guide.

If war still you choose, then resume your dear.

But if this be folly, your wrath misguided,

Better to sheath swords than mothers to weep."

The armies muttered, divided, undecided.

At last one captain, from silence deep,

Spurred horse forward, middle-aged, battle-scarred.

"I've seen enough blood and shallow heap.

My brother died under our own bombard

Last year, all for a scrap of barren land.

This stranger speaks sense, though hope comes hard.

I'll stand down arms and open a hand,

To talk before more sons and daughters fall.

I urge all leaders to meet his demand."

A cheer from some throats at this rebel call,

And grumbles from others still bent on fight,

But the momentum shifted towards sprawl.

The generals, pressured by men's weary sight,

Conceded to talk under flag of truce.

Day's battle was stayed, at least for the night.

The pilgrim sighed in relief at the sluice

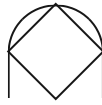
Of adrenaline drained, body now weak.

The magic shawl dimmed as urgency loosed.
 Soldiers set camp near, exchanging wary speak,
 But no blood spilled and fires were shared.
 Small signs of trust began there to leak.

One soldier brought pilgrim water and bread,
 Curious what manner of man he was.
 Another asked for a blessing on dead.
 They treated him oddly with fond applause
 Mixed with respectful distance, as if saint.
 He disavowed special favor because
 He said the Light is in all without taint;
 What he did, any soul can if they choose
 Courage and love to let hatred grow faint.
 That night around campfires, news diffuse
 That a wanderer halted war by magic,
 Stories grew tall as fear did excuse.

But the pilgrim slept apart, feeling tragic
 That war was not over, only delayed.
 He prayed unity might quell conflict's logic,
 But knew the morning's parley was unmade.
 Before dawn, he quietly left that site,
 Hoping seeds of peace among them were laid.
 His path now led up a mountain great height—
 For beyond these armies a range he saw,
 Likely the route to his next fate aright.
 Though bone-tired, he climbed as new day daw,
 Turning back once to witness rising sun
 Shine on mingled tents where foes withdraw.

It gave him hope that hatred might be undone
 When courage and wisdom in one are spun.
 Thus closed the trials of the valley dun,
 The pilgrim battered but soul victories won,
 Heading now upwards to meet tomorrow's sun.



V

Fifth Movement

ILLUMINATION

An oak. A gate. The self undone by fire.

ILLUMINATION

Climbing the heights where the air runs thin,
Our pilgrim forged on through rocky ascent.
The path was steep and narrow as a pin,
Yet drawn as if by fate, he did not relent.
Days of travel and nights under cold sky
He pressed upward, by inner zeal content.
As altitude soared, clouds drifting by,
The world below a patchwork distant dream,
He felt closer to truth he sensed nearby.
At last one dawn's light cast a golden beam
On a plateau high above verdant earth,
A summit plateau by heaven's seam.

Arriving at midday, a curious mirth
Seized him: the summit was not barren stone
But a meadow with flowers bursting forth.
Alpine blooms of every color known
Danced in sunlight under crystal air,
As if paradise on mount had been sown.
At the far end, a cliff dropped off somewhere
Beyond mortal sight—an abyss sublime.
At center, an oak tree ancient and fair
Spread its mighty branches, defying time.
Its trunk gnarled and knotted with scars of age,
Yet leaves fresh green as in youthful prime.

Under this tree, as if hermitage,
Sat a solitary figure cross-legged.
Robed in simple white garb of a sage,
Back turned to pilgrim, wholly unalleged.

Sensing presence, the figure spoke calm:
“Welcome, traveler. Your path was rugged.
Come, rest at the tree; find peace and balm.”
The pilgrim obeyed, quietly drawing near,
Feeling sweet solace as if wrapped in psalm.
He sat by the stranger with love sincere,
Noticing now an old man with shaved head,
Beard white, eyes closed as if truth were clear.

Moments passed in silence, nothing said,
But a profound communication flowed.
The pilgrim felt as if mind had been read,
That this sage without speaking all bestowed
Comfort, acknowledgment, understanding.
At length the old man’s eyes opened, glowed
With bright hazel light, compassion blending.
“You have come far, seeker of the true,
Through forest dark, desert, city tending
The suffering of others with heart anew.
Tell me, what is it that you now desire,
Here at world’s roof beneath heaven’s blue?”

The pilgrim thought deeply, as was required.
What did he yet seek? He’d learned and done
So much. Yet something deeper still aspired.
“I have beheld unity, nearly won
Peace within and without by grace and trial.
I have served love under moon and sun.
Yet still, O master, remains one dial
I cannot yet read—the ultimate goal,
To truly be that love without denial.
My hunger for truth has carved out a soul,
But I fear to carve God from my craving
Is folly. How to fully be made whole?”

The sage smiled gentle at this engraving

Of doubt laid bare by the pilgrim's artless heart.

"You fear your hunger's idol might be braving

A false god? That by your own hand and art

You've only shaped illusion to worship,

Not the reality behind the chart?"

The pilgrim nodded, each word like a whip

On self-honesty flayed raw but cleansing.

"Yes, teacher. I've seen through lies and hardship,

Yet how do I know if I am sensing

The true Beloved, or just my mind's shape?

Yearning is deep, but truth needs discerning."

The old man closed eyes briefly, then drape

One hand on the ground, the other upturned,

As if bridging earth and sky in gape.

"Your journey's lessons have by now affirmed

That paradox and union mark the Way:

In emptiness, form; through fire, life returned;

In serving others, self finds light of day.

Now comes final trial, subtle and profound:

To lose even the hunger that led your stay.

Not to kill it, but to let it drown

In the ocean that is the Beloved's grace—

To merge the seeker and sought, self unbound."

He rose smoothly to feet, in motion grace,

And beckoned the pilgrim stand up as well.

Leading to the oak's trunk broad embrace,

He placed a hand on bark, knotted and swell.

"This oak has lived through ages untold,

Burned by lightning, by drought nearly fell;

Yet each scar deepened wisdom it could hold.

In its heartwood, a hollow chamber rings—

The tree is empty, thus grows more bold.

So must you become, an empty offering:

Hollow out the last vestige of ego's claim,
Then shall your soul like this tree truly sing."

He knocked on the trunk; a resonant frame
Sounded within, echo pure and deep.
"Enter the hollow, if thou seeketh aim
To finally drink from truth's fountain steep."
The pilgrim noticed now an opening
Among roots—a doorway where one could creep.
He hesitated a moment, heart fluttering,
Then stooped and entered that wooden cave.
Inside, dim light filtered, softly uttering
Through cracks, and the scent of oak so gave
Comfort akin to incense at prayer.
The hollow trunk was snug as a grave.

Surprisingly, within there was a stair
Carved winding upward, narrow and old.
The sage's voice floated, "Ascend if you dare."
With courage steadying, he took hold
Of twisting staircase inside the tree's core,
Climbing upward through darkness uncontrolled.
The way felt endless, circling more and more,
As if ascending to another world.
His limbs grew heavy and doubt as before.
But now he recalled how illusions swirled
When nearing truth; likely one final test—
To discourage the soul with fear unfurled.

So onward he climbed, resolved and blessed,
Reciting quietly prayers from each faith
He'd learned, keeping heart and mind at rest.
At last, a glimmer above like wraith
Showed an exit from that wooden tunnel.
He emerged on a ledge, catching breath's lathe.
To his astonishment, beyond that funnel

Stretched not the meadow or sky he'd left,
 But an infinite space—stars without kennel.
 He seemed afloat in infinity, bereft
 Of the mountain, the oak, of earth below;
 The ledge he stood on hung in space, a cleft

In existence itself, where dreams grow
 Before him, an apparition took form—
 A being of light no shadow could throw.
 It wore the likeness of all he'd seen warm:
 The hermit, the hooded guide, the Sufi,
 The elder, the sage—faces shift in swarm.
 At times it was beloved friends in duty,
 At times unknown but radiantly fair,
 Male, female, and androgynous in beauty.
 Finally, it settled to one face rare—
 The pilgrim's own face, but crowned with fire,
 Eyes full of love, free of burden or care.

This self-not-self smiled and rose up higher,
 Standing upon nothing, yet firm and real.
 It spoke without sound, but clear as choir
 In the pilgrim's mind, making true appeal:
 "You have journeyed far, dear self of mine,
 Shed blood and tears in pursuit of the ideal.
 Know now that I am the one you pine
 To meet, yet I've been with you all along.
 I am the timeless soul in you, divine.
 You carved God from hunger—this was not wrong,
 For it led you onward, step after step,
 Each idol shattered when proved empty song.

Your hunger, like fire, burned dross and kept
 You seeking purer to quench the desire,
 Til at last through illusions you have leapt.
 Now standing at edge of truth's utmost spire,

Only one veil remains: the seeker's pride,
The sense of separate self you must retire."
The pilgrim trembled, though not to deride
The words—in them resonated fate's tone.
Yet what was being asked, to cast aside
His self entirely? would nothing be known?
Sensing fear, the radiant image stepped close,
Placed light-hand on heart, dispelling the lone.

In that touch, lifetimes of hurt arose,
Regrets, attachments, all hopes and all fears,
Flashed before his eyes in mournful prose.
He saw childhood loneliness, youth's lost years,
Faces of those he'd loved and lost to time,
Achievements and failures that drew out tears.
He saw the one moment sublime
When he first glimpsed the Beloved within
During the song in the temple's prime.
All these he held dear, his narrative skin,
The story that he called "me" and "my own."
To surrender this—did liberation begin?

"Will I vanish?" he asked in trembling tone.
The presence answered, "Only what is false.
Your true self divine can never be gone.
Like drop in ocean, your small ego falls
Into larger being—ceases as drop,
Yet as oceanic oneness enthralls.
You will still act, think, love, but shall adopt
The perspective of greater unity.
No longer by fears of ego be stopped."
The pilgrim-soul considered destiny,
Remembering the pain of separate life,
The glimpses of joy in community.

He thought of the valley of trials rife,

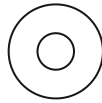
People he helped, the moments of pure grace,
 When he forgot himself in healing strife.
 Those times felt meaningful beyond replace.
 Perhaps this is the secret of saints long sung—
 To lose oneself in all, emptiness embrace.
 Steeling resolve from what bell had rung,
 He nodded slowly, ready to release,
 Trusting that love would catch him when un-sprung.
 The radiant self then gave him peace:
 “I am what happens when you set aside
 The hunger that carves false gods, and find peace.”

At that, the starry void opened wide
 Behind the figure, revealing a gate
 Formed of light in filigree undenied.
 It beckoned gently, as if to negate
 Any final doubt with allure of truth.
 The pilgrim stepped forward, embracing fate.
 At the threshold he paused, a moment sooth,
 Looked back one last time at what was “I”,
 Then with a breath stepped through as new youth.
 In blinding flash he felt himself untie—
 No, dissolve—no, expand—words cannot say,
 A drop returning to sea with soft sigh.

He felt all boundaries melting away,
 Sense of self diffused in existence entire.
 He was the sunlight dancing on the bay,
 And the bay itself, deep, living sapphire.
 He was fusion, and hydrogen, and helium,
 And the dark between, infinite quire.
 He was the laughter of children certain,
 And the tears of the grieving mother too.
 He was the questing sage and the urchin.
 He was wind on grass and the morning dew,

All at once in one vast awareness merged—
An “I” as big as the All, fresh and new.

There was no pilgrim left that could be urged,
Yet paradoxically he remained true—
A presence through which universe now surged.
How long he stayed in that union through
Beyond time’s meaning, cannot be measured,
Could be an instant or eons in lieu.
In mortal world, a flash of light treasured
Burst from the oak’s hollow and kissed the sky,
A meteor by which night was pleased.
The sage at foot of tree beheld it fly,
Smile knowingly at the sign of success,
Then closed his eyes with a contented sigh.



VI

Sixth Movement

RETURN AND REVELATION

A circle. A dawn. The hunger returned as gift.

RETURN AND REVELATION

On a quiet dawn where valley meets wood,
A traveler appeared where none had been,
Along a path near where the hermit stood
In earlier places, when journey did begin.
This traveler walked calmly, a subtle grace,
Wearing a plain brown shawl, mien genuine.
Yet something luminous shone in his face,
Though humble his pace, as of one who knows
And needs not rush, for all is in its place.
Villagers from the trial vale arose
To see who approached—some recognized him,
The kind stranger who eased their cruel woes.

Whisper ran through them: “It’s him, though eyes dim
We thought he perished on dangerous road.”
They gathered, timid joy at every limb.
He greeted each by name though time had flowed,
Remembering their faces, wounds and fears—
They marveled: “How long our paths since you showed?”
For to them, many months had passed in tears,
But to him, the journey was beyond time,
His transformation unbound by our years.
He stayed with them again, and without chime
Healed the sick with just research and a prayer,
The famine ended as crops longed for life.

Rain came gentle that spring, the fields grew fair;
Those bandits he’d met returned, now changed men,
Bringing supplies and building homes with care.
The armies from war’s brink—news traveled then—

Had signed a truce, leaders influenced
By a wanderer's courage, remembering when.
Our traveler worked humbly, not pretenced
As holy above, but each task he met—
From mending shoes to teaching with patience.
Wherever he went, hearts and minds were set
Alight by his presence quiet and pure,
He listened deeply to all in regret.

When asked what faith he followed, to assure
If he was prophet, or wizard, or saint,
He answered simply, "One beyond borders.
All faiths hold truth, all hearts in love acquaint.
I come not to build another temple,
But to help each soul from darkness to faint."
He spoke with authority yet gentle,
Quoting scriptures of many a tradition
With ease, making each as his own supple.
Transformation came not by derision
But by parables that made people think,
Challenging dogmas with loving vision.

In one town's square, near a fountain's brink,
He engaged a scholar and a priest both,
On nature of truth from which all men drink.
The priest insisted salvation was growth
Only through his creed's exclusive portal.
The scholar argued reason was the troth—
If not empirical, truth's chaff mortal.
They turned to the pilgrim for his reply.
He answered with a story, not chortle:
"Once a traveler, parched under midday sky,
Found a well guarded by a stern old man.
'Only my bucket draws water,' his cry.

Another wanderer came with his plan,

Saying, 'No rope but mine can reach the deep.'
 They argued which way was the proper span
 While the traveler still thirsted in keep.
 Tiring, he simply clambered down the wall,
 And drank from the source where waters do leap.
 Truth's well is abundant, and gives to all;
 Buckets and ropes are our creeds and logic—
 Useful, but secondary in the call.
 Better we climb down to taste—to frolic
 In direct experience of the source,
 Than die of thirst amid debates prologic.”

Some folks gasped; the priest saw threat of course
 To authority; the scholar, offense
 At a truth beyond mind's experimental force.
 But most laughed gently, and saw the sense:
 That love and direct seeking of the Real
 Trump quarrels over method and defense.
 The priest, to save face, said with wounded zeal,
 “So you claim all religions equal stand?”
 The traveler replied, “No, not ideal,
 For each is unique as each culture's hand.
 But all hands can lift the soul to what's right,
 If the heart within beats love as command.”

Rumors of a wise teacher shone bright
 Traveled afar to ears of city grand,
 And from Beloved City came invite.
 The pilgrim returned there at the demand
 Of old friends—the children now grown in grace,
 The elders who recalled him leaving land.
 He found the city flourishing, a place
 That had sent emissaries to all sides,
 Spreading seeds of knowledge, healing and place.
 They welcomed him with festival besides,

Honoring not him (for he would not allow),
But the truth he carried under disguise.

In the Temple, he spoke from oculus glow,
Not from scripture scroll or doctrine's decree,
But sharing fruits of the journey's long flow.
His words juxtaposed Eastern and Western tree
Into one garland of wisdom and love,
Stressing virtues of integrity.
He taught that the search itself is enough,
That questions when honest can lead to light,
That doubt can refine instead of rebuff.
He urged compassion, that we must unite
In care for each other, all life as kin,
For the divine spark in all is alight.

There were controversial points within:
He cautioned priests not to hoard divine grace,
Challenged kings that the poor's plight is their sin.
Subtle his language, never naming face,
But those with ears to hear knew the aim—
Corrupt in power grew red in disgrace.
Yet because he spoke not in anger flame
But in sorrow that such potential bleeds,
His censure cut deep yet left little blame.
People left inspired to better deeds,
Not just in awe of the mystic speaker,
But resolved to plant love's humble seeds.

After the talk, as twilight crowned with stars,
He wandered to garden 'neath olive tree
Where he first had vision that healed his scars.
A familiar presence then he could see—
The Sufi woman, or was it the guide,
Or the sage? It was all, smiling calmly.
He bowed low, they embraced with no more pride

Between them, for they were truly one Soul
 Now meeting itself on life's other side.
 No words were needed; in silence whole
 They communicated gratitude and joy.
 At length the figure spoke, "The final goal

Is realized, yet work remains, dear boy."
 The traveler laughed, for he was quite old
 In years by now, though spirit in buoy.
 "Yes, always the work. But with heart of gold
 It becomes dance and song, not mere duty.
 I will carry on until body cold
 Returns to dust. Then what comes, let it be."
 The figure nodded and slowly faded,
 Merging into night as subtle beauty.
 He remained by the tree, bliss pervaded,
 Until a young acolyte found him there,
 To escort him where kindly bed was laid.

He lived among city folk for a year,
 Teaching by day, in meditation deep
 At night, bridging earth with heavenly sphere.
 Yet he knew soon his promise he must keep—
 To return to where it started, forest gloom,
 To the hermit or whoever gave leap.
 Thus one morning, quiet as dawn in bloom,
 He left city's warmth for the wild again,
 Following memory's signal through glume.
 The road seemed shorter; he knew it attain
 When twilight found him by the ancient wood,
 The same dark forest where he met the pain.

Entering beneath that canopy stood
 Just as in youth, but now unafraid
 Of shadows whispering fear as they would.
 He followed instinct, a spirit conveyed,

To find that clearing where stone doorway gaped;
He half-wondered if hermit still replayed.
To his surprise, by moon's light that draped,
He found the very rock by cedar lined,
But broken in two as if earth quaked.
The portal was gone, just ruin assigned.
He stepped into the glade and found no man,
No hermit waiting with wisdom opined.

Instead, at center, a small fire began—
Crackling orange, newly lit, inviting.
He approached slowly, and saw of a span
A circle of stones set round as writing.
The fire beckoned him closer to sit;
As he did so, the woods came alighting.
From behind trunks, figures came to flit:
The hermit in red, the hooded guide dark,
The white-robed sage, the Sufi exquisite,
The elder, the child, and more to remark—
Faces from all moments and trials severe.
They ringed him silently, each a soul-mark.

He realized these were forms held most dear
In journey, but more—archetypes of soul,
The Beloved's masks to draw him near.
They glowed faint, each like an aureole,
Neither fully flesh nor phantom mere,
As if present and absent on patrol.
Then from the fire a voice crystal clear:
"Thou art returned, and we are well pleased.
The wood of the world thou hast carved sincere,
Not into idol, but icon that eased
The path for others to glimpse the divine.
Thus hunger transmuted to love increased."

All in the circle nodded in design.

The pilgrim spoke out, voice echoing strong,
Addressing them all or That in their sign:

"It was you who guided me all along—
But you are me as well, I understand.

The line between self and other is gone.

Thus carving the god from hunger so grand

Only succeeded once I shattered the 'I'.

Now whatever you ask, I'll do at hand."

The figures smiled in unison to imply

Approval. The hermit stepped forth and said,

"Your tale must be told so others might try."

The hooded guide: "In hearts must you embed

The truth that seeking is a sacred art."

The sage: "That emptiness and form be wed."

The Sufi: "That love's fire be lit in heart."

The elder: "That wisdom with compassion blend."

The child: "That innocence and wonder never depart."

All voices together: "Go forth, dear friend,

In the world of men your journey goes on.

This moment closes, another will impend."

He bowed to each, then by break of dawn

They vanished like mist, one final farewell.

He stood alone as new day was born.

He quenched the fire and left the glade as well,

Heart full, steps light, though tears in eyes did swell—

Not of sorrow, but joy's overflowing bell.

He realized a circle had been traveled,

From hunger to wholeness, all drama befell.

A final thought in his mind unraveled,

As tolling bell or last line to infer,

To etch what his entire journey marveled:

*I am what happens
when you try to carve God
from the wood
of your own hunger.*

About the Author

Kevin L. Michel writes philosophical, poetic, civic, and self-development works for readers trying to live with more clarity, courage, discipline, imagination, and inner authority. His books move between practical strategy, mythic reflection, spiritual allegory, and the everyday work of becoming more fully human.